

Chapter 177-13

Seeing this scene, Liang Shi didn't know what to say for a moment.

She had originally thought she would feel some kind of apprehension about returning home¹, but at this moment she felt fine.

Probably because she had spent over a month building herself up mentally, so she didn't have much of a reaction.

Until Zhu Mingqi opened her mouth and called out to her: "A-Shi."

"Auntie Zhu." Liang Shi still greeted her the same way.

This single sentence made Zhu Mingqi's eyes turn red. Shen Yaobo supported her while also staring fixedly at Liang Shi.

Shen Siyan asked in disbelief: "You're really my third sister?"

Liang Shi: "...The DNA test report says so."

Shen Siyan pinched her ear and said awkwardly: "Alright then."

Then she was the first to call out: "Third Sister."

Liang Shi: "?"

Shen Fenghe and Shen Hui were also staring at her, their expressions seeming to say—aren't you going to greet us?

But Liang Shi didn't call out to them. She took half a step back and stood beside Xu Qingzhu. "I'm not mentally prepared yet."

"When will you be mentally prepared?" Zhu Mingqi immediately said. "I can wait."

Liang Shi: "..."

These words were too heartbreaking. Liang Shi immediately felt embarrassed.

But most importantly, Liang Shi looked at them: "How did you all find out?"

Then her gaze turned to Zhao Xuning. Zhao Xuning shrugged: "Although I was the one who said it in the end, even if I didn't say it, someone else would have, so I just said it. You understand?"

This long tongue-twister was hard to follow.

But Liang Shi understood.

She sat on the sofa, facing this large group of people in silence.

She could only relieve her awkwardness and nervousness by constantly squeezing Xu Qingzhu's fingers.

Zhu Mingqi had been carefully not moving, but her eyes kept glancing toward Liang Shi. Every five minutes she would ask Liang Shi: "Are you mentally prepared yet?"

The tearful dramatic scene she had expected didn't arrive. This family was quite rational.

Everyone was waiting for Liang Shi to make a decision.

Even the workaholic Shen Fenghe didn't go to the company.

After about half an hour of awkward silence, Liang Shi spoke up first: "Why do you want to acknowledge me?"

Zhu Mingqi felt her question made no sense and answered her matter-of-factly: "You're my daughter. When I didn't know, that was one thing. Now that I know, why wouldn't I acknowledge you? I carried you for ten months and gave birth to you."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "But I've already grown up now. If I come back, I might disrupt your existing balance, so... wouldn't it be better to pretend not to know?"

This was what Liang Shi had been worried about all along.

But the moment these words came out, Zhu Mingqi's eyes welled up with tears. Even Shen Hui secretly got red-eyed.

Zhu Mingqi walked over and half-knelt in front of Liang Shi. She raised her hand to touch her face and said in a choked voice: "You are my daughter. What balance is there to talk about? You should be part of this family. I'm so sorry you've grown up, but I've already missed more than twenty years of watching you grow. How can I miss any more of your growth?"

By the end, she was already sobbing uncontrollably.

Zhu Mingqi's tears fell like rain as she choked out: "What parent would ever despise their own child? I carried you for ten months and gave birth to you—I never thought about any balance. Just how much have you suffered that you always think of others first?"

Liang Shi was suddenly struck in the softest place of her heart.

Even Xu Qingzhu felt her heart ache when she heard that last sentence.

Pregnant women were already emotionally sensitive to begin with, and a tear dropped directly.

Liang Shi's eyes also reddened.

When no one was there to comfort you, you felt like you could weather any storm alone.

But once someone showed concern, once someone asked if you'd been doing well all these years, you would suddenly feel wronged.

The truth was, things hadn't been good.

Fighting alone in an unfamiliar place.

When others were warmly reuniting amid the lights of countless homes, she was watching TV in a cold, lonely house.

No one around her, emptiness in her heart.

Zhu Mingqi was choking up so much she could barely speak: "Come home from now on. Your family won't let you suffer anymore. Wherever Mom and Dad are, that's your home."

Liang Shi's tears fell. She had thought she could hold it in well, but she ended up crying out loud anyway.

It wasn't earth-shattering crying, just soft sobbing.

Yet it revealed all the hardships and grievances she had endured over the years.

She had originally thought acknowledging her relatives was a big deal that would overturn her existing life.

But just like when Xu Qingzhu acknowledged Su Yao before, it seemed big, but it was actually just a big emotional change.

All day long she had been tangled up in her own thoughts, exhausting herself internally.

When she actually acknowledged them, she discovered it was just a small matter in life.

Life would go on as it should.

Except... there were now more bonds.

After Liang Shi's matters trended, there were also follow-ups.

The author Wenchuan posted a Weibo: If Qiao Wenyu has a prototype, it's @LiangShi. The story of two little girls saving each other in childhood—no one can understand it better than her. Jiao-jie is Xu Jiao, but also the Jiao in my life that I don't want to mention, and also the Jiao who once warmed her childhood.

I'm also grateful that she pulled me out of the mire.

As for her character, people can judge for themselves.

When Liang Shi finished being busy and went online, she also saw this Weibo post. She felt like it was all very confusing.

Until Gu Xingyue sent her a WeChat message: 【Have you finished reading the script? I'm planning to write the second part, "Blade."】

Liang Shi: 【???】

It was only then that she learned Gu Xingyue was Wenchuan.

And the two characters "Wenchuan" (文川) were derived from "Qi" (齊)².

The extra stroke at the bottom also represented her refusal to give in to this world.

Beyond her shock, Liang Shi also understood where all those feelings she'd had before came from.

Because those were all things she had experienced.

Qiao Wenyu in the book was her. Xu Jiao was her.

And the one who endured so much suffering and finally saw the light of day was still her.

Thankfully, there was still Qi Jiao, still Gu Xingyue.

They all found their way to the light in different places.

Footnotes:

¹ "Apprehension about returning home" (近鄉情怯, jìn xiāng qíng qiè) - A Chinese idiom describing the mixed feelings of nervousness and anxiety one feels when approaching home after a long absence, particularly when uncertain about what reception awaits.

² The pen name "Wenchuan" (文川) is a clever wordplay. The Chinese character "齊" (Qí, as in Qi Jiao's surname) can be split into components that loosely resemble "文" (wén, literature/writing) and "川" (chuān, river/streams). By adding an extra stroke, it transforms into something new while retaining a connection to the original character—symbolizing Gu Xingyue's determination to forge a new identity while honoring Qi Jiao's memory.